

ApexNova Commerce Group

Customer Management Guidelines - 2020

1. Refund Policy

The organization maintains a conservative refund policy designed to protect both the business and its customers from fraudulent or erroneous return claims. Refunds are permitted exclusively within a 7-day window from the original date of purchase, after which no refund requests will be considered regardless of circumstance. Only cash refunds are available at this time; no alternative reimbursement methods such as store credit, bank transfers, or card reversals are supported by the current point-of-sale infrastructure. A physical receipt in its original paper form is mandatory for all refund requests without exception. Photocopies, handwritten notes, or verbal confirmations of purchase are not accepted as valid proof. Employees must verify that the receipt matches the item being returned, including product code, purchase date, and store location. All refund transactions must be processed at the same store location where the original purchase was made; cross-store refunds are not supported. Items must be returned in their original, unopened packaging with all seals, tags, and protective materials intact. Any sign of use, tampering, or repackaging will result in automatic denial of the refund request. No partial refunds are permitted under any circumstances. The item must be returned in full or not at all. Manager approval is required for any refund transaction exceeding 50 euro. Employees must not process such refunds independently, even if all other conditions are met. In cases where a customer disputes the refund decision, the employee must politely explain the policy, offer to involve a manager, and document the interaction on the daily incident log. The organization acknowledges that this policy is relatively strict compared to industry norms and plans to review it annually based on operational feedback and fraud incident data.

2. Theft & Incident Handling

The organization takes a zero-tolerance approach to theft while simultaneously prioritizing the physical safety of all employees, customers, and third parties present in the store environment. In cases of suspected theft, employees are required to strictly observe the situation from a safe distance and report their observations to the duty manager as quickly and discreetly as possible. Under no circumstances are employees permitted to verbally confront, question, accuse, or engage with the suspected individual. Any form of direct intervention, including standing in doorways, following the person through aisles, or making comments intended to deter or embarrass, is strictly prohibited. Employees must not block exits, follow suspects outside the premises, attempt to recover merchandise from the individual's possession, or physically touch the person in any way. Such actions expose

the organization to legal liability and create unacceptable safety risks for all parties involved. The duty manager is solely responsible for deciding whether to contact in-store security (where available) or law enforcement. This decision must not be made by frontline employees regardless of their level of certainty about the situation. Incident observations should be written down on the standard paper incident form (available at the service desk) within 30 minutes of the event. The form must include the date, time, store area, a factual description of what was observed, the products believed to be involved, and any distinguishing details that may assist in later review. Descriptions must remain strictly factual and objective. Employees must not include assumptions, speculation about motives, racial or demographic profiling, emotional language, or personal opinions in their incident reports. Employee safety takes absolute precedence over merchandise recovery. No item, regardless of its value, justifies placing an employee in a potentially dangerous situation. This principle is non-negotiable and applies uniformly across all store locations and operating hours. Employees who witness an incident and feel distressed or unsafe are encouraged to notify their manager and request a brief break if needed. The organization recognizes that witnessing theft or confrontational behavior can be stressful and supports employee wellbeing in such circumstances. All completed incident forms are collected weekly by the store manager, reviewed for completeness, and forwarded to the regional loss-prevention coordinator for trend analysis and pattern identification.

3. Customer Communication

Effective customer communication is recognized as a foundational element of service quality, and all employees are expected to maintain basic politeness, patience, and professional conduct during every customer interaction regardless of the customer's tone or attitude. At this stage, no specific structured communication framework is mandated by the organization. Employees are trusted to use common sense, courtesy, and their own professional judgment when engaging with customers, resolving queries, or handling routine service requests. Greetings and farewells are recommended as a matter of good practice and professional etiquette, but their use is not formally monitored, measured, or enforced through any performance tracking system. When a customer raises a complaint, the employee should listen patiently and without interruption, allowing the customer to express their concern fully before responding. If the complaint cannot be resolved through simple explanation or immediate action within approximately 5 minutes, the employee must direct the customer to the duty manager for further assistance. Employees should avoid making promises or commitments that they are not authorized to fulfill. Phrases such as 'I will make sure this is fixed' or 'We will definitely refund you' should be avoided unless the employee has explicit authority to deliver on that promise. There are no formal response time targets for in-store interactions at this time. The organization trusts employees to manage their time appropriately and to balance customer attention with other operational duties. All written communication with customers, including letters, printed notices, signage, and any correspondence sent by post, must be reviewed and

approved by a manager before dispatch or display. This applies to both individual customer correspondence and general notices intended for public visibility. Employees must avoid the use of slang, overly casual language, or internal jargon when speaking with customers. Communication should be clear, professional, and easily understood by a general audience. In situations where a language barrier exists, employees should make reasonable efforts to assist the customer through simple language, gestures, or by finding a colleague who may be able to help. Translation services are not currently available in-store. The organization plans to introduce a more structured communication framework in future policy revisions based on feedback from store managers and customer satisfaction survey results.

4. Documentation

Accurate and timely documentation of incidents, complaints, and notable customer interactions is an essential operational discipline that supports accountability, trend analysis, and legal protection for both the organization and its employees. All incident reports must be completed on the standard paper forms available at the service desk. These forms are pre-printed with guided fields to help employees capture the required information in a structured and consistent manner. Reports must be filed manually in the store's designated physical filing cabinet within 24 hours of the incident. Late submissions compromise the reliability of the record and may result in a reminder from the store manager. Each report must include at minimum: the date and time of the incident, the specific store location or area where it occurred, the full name and employee ID of the person completing the report, a clear and factual description of the event, any actions taken in response, and the signature of the reviewing manager confirming the report has been read. The store manager is responsible for compiling weekly incident summaries based on the filed reports. These summaries are sent to the regional office by fax or post no later than the following Monday. The regional office uses these summaries to track patterns across stores and identify locations that may require additional support or staffing. Digital systems are not used for incident documentation at this time. The organization has evaluated several digital platforms but has not yet approved one for deployment. Until a digital system is implemented, the paper-based process remains the official and sole method of record-keeping. The retention period for paper records is 2 years from the date of filing. After this period, records are securely shredded in accordance with the organization's document destruction policy. Records involved in ongoing investigations or legal proceedings are exempt from routine destruction and must be retained until clearance is received from the legal team. Employees are reminded that documentation is not optional. Even minor incidents that appear insignificant at the time may become relevant in hindsight if a pattern emerges or a formal complaint is later filed. When in doubt, employees should complete a report and allow the manager to assess its significance during the weekly review.

5. Data Protection & Privacy

The organization recognizes the importance of customer privacy and expects all employees to treat customer information with basic confidentiality and professional discretion at all times. Customer data, including names, phone numbers, home addresses, email addresses, and any financial details shared during transactions, must not be spoken aloud in public areas where other customers or unauthorized individuals might overhear. Employees should lower their voice or move to a more private area when discussing sensitive customer details. At this time, no formal written data access protocols or digital access control systems are in place. Employees are expected to use good judgment regarding what information they access, when they access it, and for what purpose. Accessing customer data out of curiosity, for personal reasons, or for any purpose unrelated to a current business transaction is considered a breach of trust. ID verification is not currently required for refund transactions regardless of value. The organization relies on receipt verification as the primary fraud control mechanism for returns and refunds. Customer purchase history stored in the point-of-sale system is accessible to all store employees without restriction. While this open access supports efficient customer service, employees are reminded that viewing transaction history should only occur when there is a legitimate and immediate business need to do so. In exceptional circumstances where a store phone is unavailable, employees may use personal devices to contact customers regarding order pickups, delivery arrangements, or appointment confirmations. However, customer phone numbers must be deleted from personal devices immediately after the call is completed. Storing customer contact details on personal devices for any extended period is not permitted. No formal data protection training program is mandated at this time. Employees receive a brief overview of confidentiality expectations during onboarding, but no ongoing refresher training is currently provided. The organization plans to introduce a more comprehensive data protection awareness program in the coming year as part of a broader compliance initiative. Employees who observe or suspect a breach of customer confidentiality by a colleague should report the matter to their manager promptly. Such reports will be handled discreetly and without retaliation against the reporting employee.